BOOK REVIEWS

ISLAND *Bloodline*



By Ajoy Bose

Ajay Singh, whose *Fiji: A Love Story (Memoirs of an Unconventional Diplomat)* has just been posthumously published, was indeed a very unconventional plenipotentiary. Before he was selected as India's envoy to Fiji in 2005, Singh had led a life that was as extraordinary as it was varied. He was a radical activist in St Stephen's College and also helped shape the pioneering news fortnightly INDIA TODAY. After the fall of the Emergency regime, he was appointed managing trustee of the Kisan trust by peasant patriarch and former prime minister Charan Singh. Within a decade, he was elected to the Lok Sabha and became a minister in the short-lived Janata Dal government.

Yet his diplomatic sojourn had a very special place in Ajay Singh's heart. Few would have guessed that the urbane, witty Ajay had a Fiji bond stretching well over a century, from the time his great-grandfather Ram Chander sailed the high seas to become an indentured labourer there. Later, his father Bhagwan Singh was the first Indian high commissioner to Fiji when it attained independence in 1970. Ajay married a third-generation Fijian of Indian origin, Shiromani.

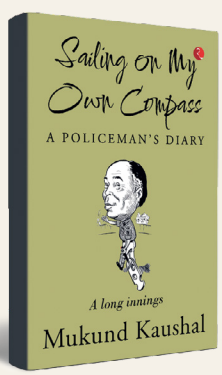
The book, written in an easy, flowing style, traces the long and winding history of this unique bond with fascinating anecdotes. The family history includes the incarceration of Ajay's great-grandfather Ram Chander in Suva jail for nearly three years on trumped-up charges after a fight between two rival gangs of labourers and his return some years later to his native land, the return of his son Bere Singh to Fiji to work in the civil service there for 16 years before coming back to India and Bere's son Bhagwan Singh's top diplomatic posting in Fiji. It underlines the family tradition that Ajay must have felt he was carrying forward in his mission to the island state.

AJAY'S LUCIDLY WRITTEN MEMOIR TRACES HIS FAMILY'S LONG, COMPLEX TIES WITH FIJI

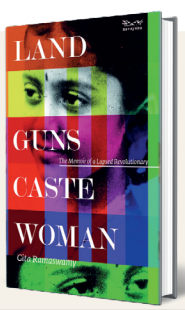
However, his ancestral ties with Fiji were only part of Ajay's love affair with that country. His real passion was triggered by

A HOLSTERED ACCOUNT

A bildungsroman of sorts set in late 20th century India, this senior policeman's memoir follows a colourful trajectory from provincial thanas to urban criminals to the opaque demeanours and misdemeanours of politicians in the heart of government. Kaushal has clearly had an interesting career and highlights range from casebook classics like cracking the 'sensational abduction of an antique(s) dealer' to negotiating with separatists of many stripes including the Hizbul Mujahideen, the NSCN(IM) and the GNLF. Kaushal's restraint is always evident and was presumably an asset in these assignments. But the reader may wish for more of a tell-all. There is a particularly intriguing lacuna in his narrative of the 1970s which leaps from a posting as IGP of Goa, Daman and Diu in 1974 to the security details of PM Morarji Desai in 1978. It seems almost impertinent to ask but one wonders where he spent the (cough) Emergency. ■



SAILING ON MY OWN COMPASS
A policeman's diary
by Mukund Kaushal
RUPA ₹495



LAND GUNS CASTE WOMAN
The Memoir of a Lapsed Revolutionary
Gita Ramaswamy
NAVAYANA ₹599

STILL THE WARRIOR

There was a time when 'social juctice warrior' was not a term of derision and Gita Ramaswamy's affecting memoir will remind you of those days—if you're old enough. Her complex if not entirely unfamiliar trajectory—from Tam-brahm civil servant's daughter, to student naxal to